

Pictograms

01

Did you know that we can use only graphics to convey information or a message? Let me show you how.



“A picture is worth a thousand words”. We have heard this phrase many times. It means that a picture conveys more information than just words can. Complex ideas can sometimes be conveyed with just one picture. An image gives physical and visual form to an idea.

1. Pictograms

Look at the image shown. Observe how the picture communicates without any words.

The sign conveys: Descend stairs with caution, you may fall and hurt yourself.



Such signs universally convey the same messages. They can be understood by people from all parts of the world. They can also be understood by people who cannot read.

For example:



lavar as mãos

हँस घेहे

мыть руки

Wash hands

হাত ধোয়া

опрати руке

اغسل يديك

Bytes

Semiotics: Semiotics is the study of signs.

Signs and symbols are all around us. We commonly use them for navigation. For example: road signs help people to identify traffic rules, whether they are literate or not. We come across such signs multiple times in our daily lives. They may be printed or digital.



Printed stop sign



Digital stop sign

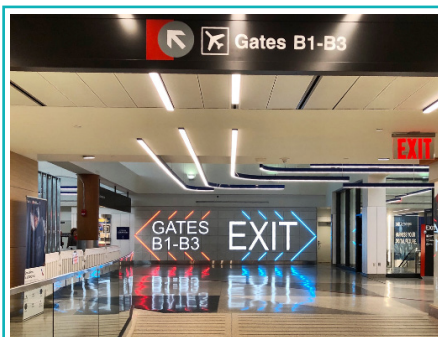
Signs act as wayfinding systems for our lives. A wayfinding system helps us navigate complex environments by providing directions that guide us. An effective wayfinding system includes:

- Well-structured paths
- Simple and easy to understand directions
- Important landmarks
- Understanding the needs of the user

1. Pictograms

Wayfinding systems are important in modern cities as cities have complex routes and manmade environments with multiple directions. Pictograms are used to visually represent words, such as those written in local languages. Pictograms are easy for everyone to understand. They are also used to represent cultural symbols and cues.

For example: Signs at an airport



Exercise

Identify the meanings of the following signs:

1



2



3



4



5



To create effective signs, keep following in mind:

- Use meaningful icons to convey information
- Use relevant icons
- Use clear text styles which are easy to read

Different types of Signs

Iconic Signs: A sign that directly represents the object it is referring to.

For example: A petrol pump sign



Indexical Signs: A sign that suggests a cause-and-effect relationship between the sign and its meaning.

For example: The concept of fire can be explained with smoke because it indicates the presence of fire.



Symbolic Signs: A sign that clearly explains its meaning.

For example: The sign clearly shows silhouettes of a woman and a man. It is commonly seen outside washrooms.



A **sign** placed at a particular **location** creates an impression and triggers a specific **action** for the viewer.

Signs that are used to determine an action for the viewer are termed as Pictograms. A **pictogram** is a symbol that conveys the meaning of an object or an idea in the form of a drawing.

While designing a pictogram, define the expected action and determine the location where the sign will be used. A good pictogram should be simple enough to be universally understood. Colour schemes should be clean and distinguishable. A single pictogram shouldn't have too many colours. If a new pictogram is added to an already existing set, it should relate with the others in terms of drawing style, shape, colour etc.

1. Pictograms

Pictograms can be of various types:

Process driven/directional

A process driven or directional pictogram is used for navigation or guidance while travelling.

For example: Follow the correct lanes



Authoritative

Authoritative pictograms are commanding in nature. They give specific instructions that need to be followed.

For example: No cell phones allowed



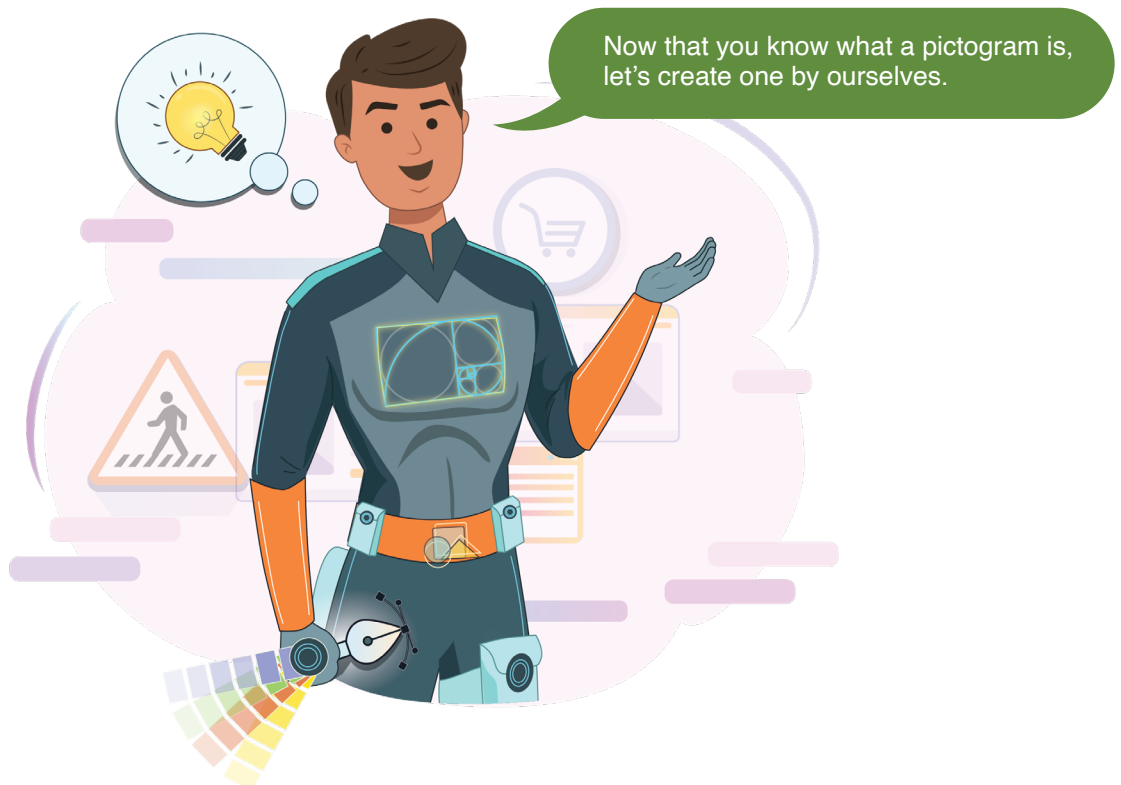
Open ended

Open ended pictograms have multiple meanings. The meaning varies depending on the location where the sign is placed.

For example: The shown pictogram can be a symbol for a package or a gift.



Pictograms communicate essential facts or instructions through images.



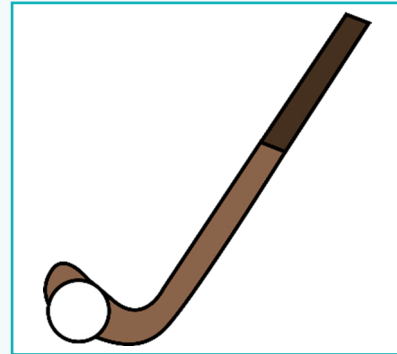
Activity

Design a pictogram to indicate that a ground is designated to play Hockey.

1 Ideate

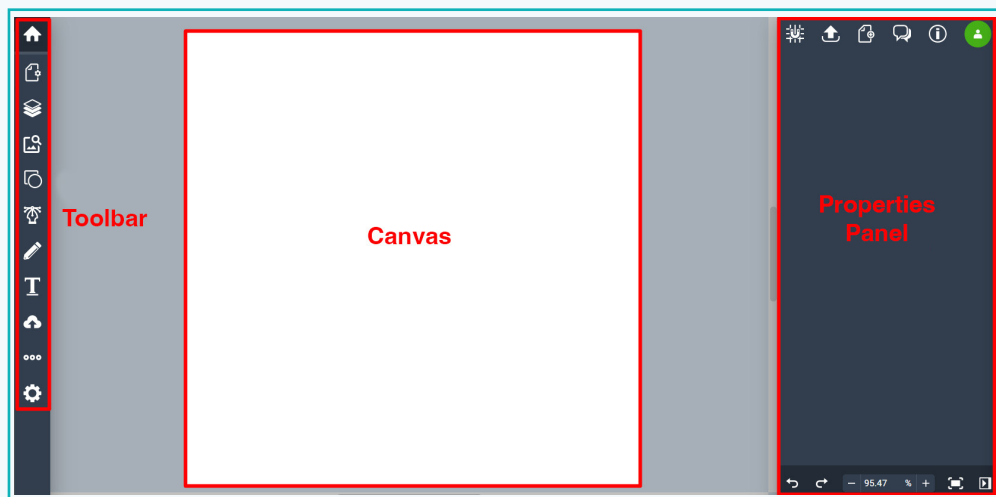
Hockey is a sport played on grass fields and featured at the Olympics. It is played with wooden sticks called Hockey Sticks and a ball.

An element that can be clearly used to represent the sport is a hockey stick. We also require supporting elements to convey the message. We can refer to the image shown.



a. Load vectr.com in the browser.

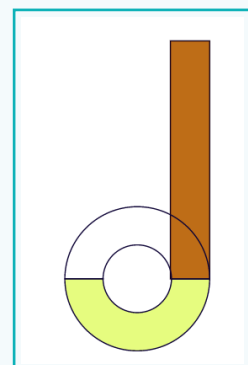
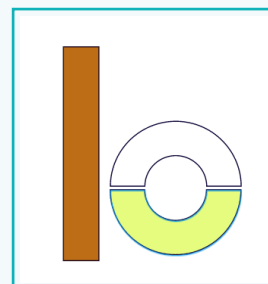
We will use two parts of the interface for this activity: the toolbar and the canvas.



The canvas is the area where we design an artwork. The toolbar consists of tools that are used to create an artwork.

Let us try to create the hockey stick and ball using basic shapes.

b. Observe the shape of the stick. The shaft can be created using a rectangle, and the base can be created using a ring.

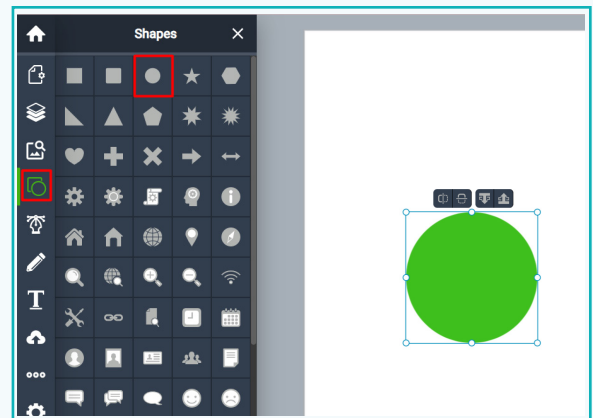


Activity

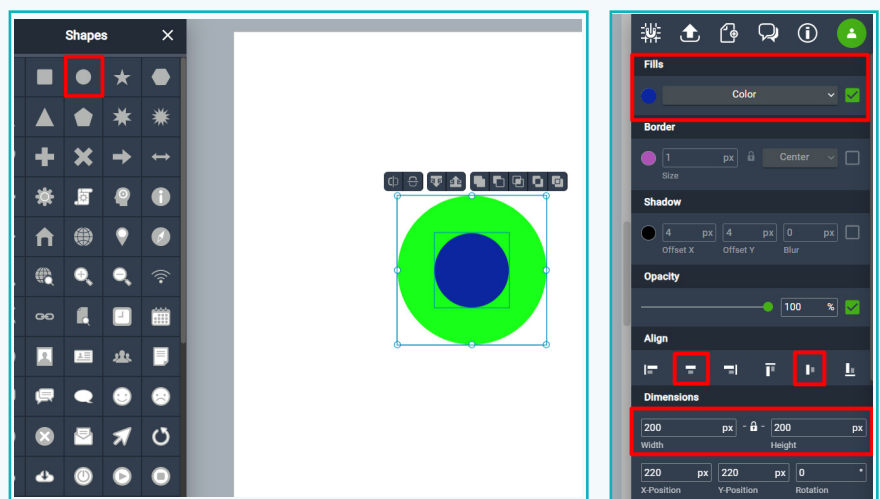
2 Design

Let us start with the base of the hockey stick:

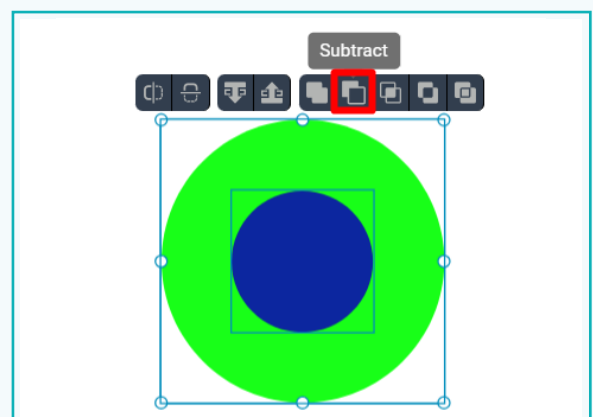
a. Use the 'shapes tool' to draw a circle for the base.



b. Create a smaller circle, with the centre of the first circle.



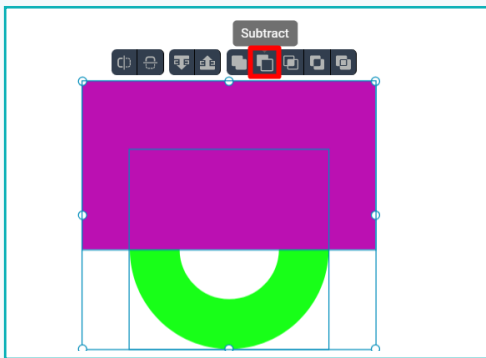
c. Holding the shift key, select both shapes. Subtract the inner circle from the outer as shown to create a ring using Subtract Tool.



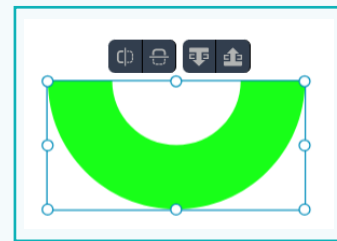
Activity

The **subtract** tool removes the overlaying shape from the parent shape.

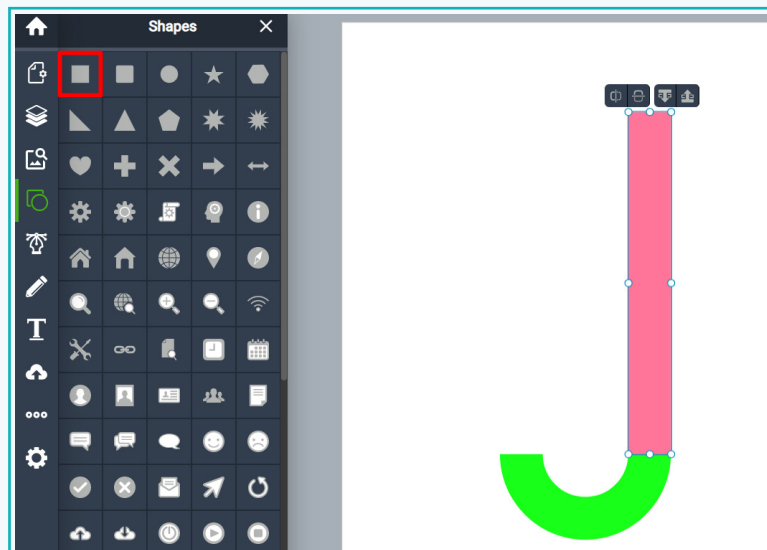
- d. To remove the upper half of the ring, create a rectangle overlaying the half of the ring. Subtract it to get a shape for the base of the hockey stick.



Result:



- e. Now, create a rectangle for the shaft of the stick.

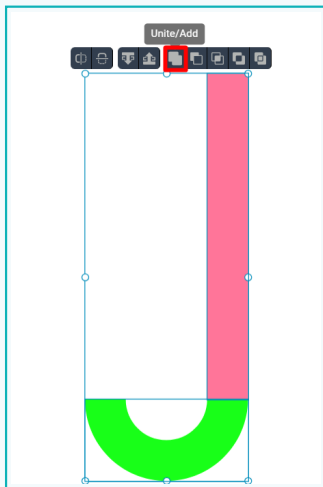


- f. Unite both objects to create one shape.

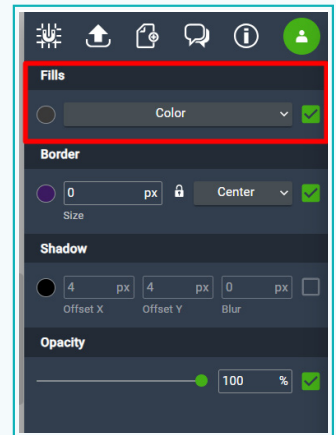
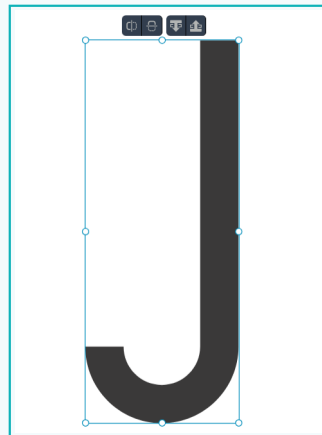
Activity

f. Unite both objects to create one shape.

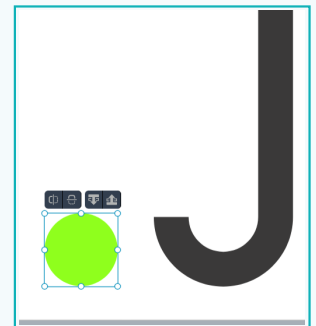
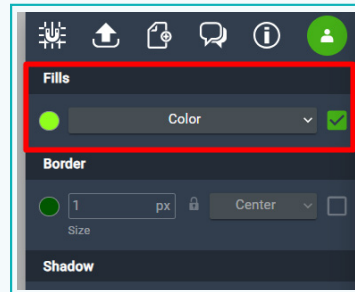
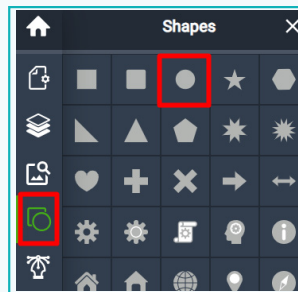
The unite tool adds or merges the selected shapes to create a single shape.



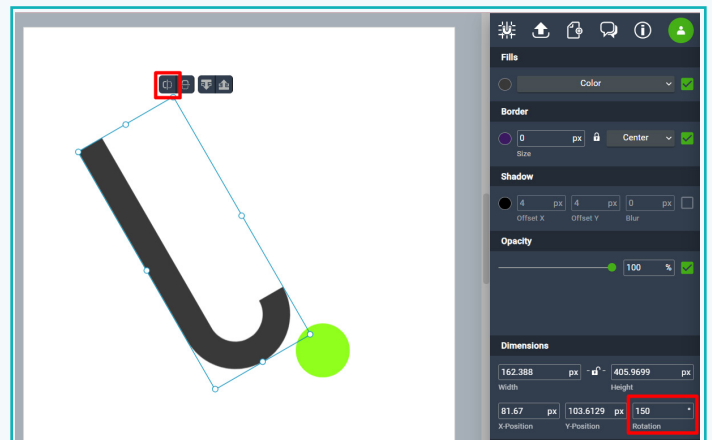
Result:



g. Create a circle to represent a ball.



h. Rotate and position the objects as required using the properties panel.



Exercise

Fill in the blanks

- 6 The _____ tool removes the overlaying shape from the parent shape.
- 7 The _____ tool adds/merges the selected shapes to create a single shape.
- 8 Holding the _____ key allows us to select multiple shapes.
- 9 The size, position and orientation (angle of rotation) can be set in the dimension parameters of the _____ panel.

Activity

We also need a character to convey our message, along with the hockey stick.

3 Enhance and improvise

- a. Use the same technique with shapes to create a character.

The final pictograph should look like this:



Signs are the language of the visual world. They help convey information without using words. There are many different types of signs that help us navigate in our day-to-day life. We can create our own signs using a vector application.

1. Pictograms

A pictogram is a simplified form of visual communication that delivers information without words.



Tech Flash

- **Semiotics** : Semiotics is the study of signs.
- **Pictogram** : A pictogram is a symbol that conveys meaning through its resemblance to a physical object.